Still-Face Disruption of Expected Social Contingency

When a familiar adult suddenly becomes unresponsive in face-to-face interaction, infants typically protest, look away, and try to re-engage; this is a laboratory signature of expected contingency, not a diagnosis of attachment or co-regulation failure.

GRADE: HIGH-LAB; LOW-ATTACHMENT-VERDICT | STATUS: STABLE | DOMAIN: EMOTION, REGULATION | REPLICATION: VERIFIED

WHAT WE KNOW (Narrowest Supported Conclusion)

In the still-face procedure, a familiar adult who has been interacting normally becomes suddenly unresponsive. Infants typically reduce smiling, increase negative affect and gaze aversion, and often try to re-engage the adult. Tronick, Als, Adamson, Wise & Brazelton (1978) established the laboratory signature. Mesman, van IJzendoorn & Bakermans-Kranenburg (2009) synthesized decades of replications: the protest/re-engagement pattern is robust as a procedure effect, not as a personality score.

EVIDENCE AND CAUSAL ASSESSMENT

The design is experimental: the same adult, the same infant, a controlled change in contingency. That is stronger than a correlational "synchrony score." It is still a laboratory episode. Mesman et al. (2009) document heterogeneity by age, coding, and recovery-period measurement. The existing co-regulation card covers bidirectional regulation as a construct; this card covers one experimental disruption of that process. Sleep and attachment-intervention cards are not restated.

EFFECT SIZE AND PERSISTENCE

The classic result is a within-episode change in affect and looking, not a portable standardized "regulation trait." Persistence as a forecast of later competence is not what the paradigm measures.

BIAS, HETEROGENEITY, AND CONFOUNDING

GI attenuation: n/a. Cultural display rules, infant state, and how "recovery" is coded all move the score. A difficult still-face is not institutional deprivation.

WHAT THIS DOES NOT MEAN (Strict Boundary Conditions)

Does not mean a distressed still-face proves insecure attachment or parental failure. Distress is information about broken contingency, not a purity test. Co-regulation is not constant calm.

WHAT ACTION IS REASONABLY JUSTIFIED

Ordinary, repairable interaction is consistent with the finding. Training parents to "pass" a still-face, or ranking infants by protest, does not follow.

VERIFIED SOURCES & DOI IDENTIFIERS

- Tronick, Als, Adamson, Wise & Brazelton (1978), Journal of the American Academy of Child Psychiatry
- Mesman, van IJzendoorn & Bakermans-Kranenburg (2009), Developmental Review